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Identifying physical barriers through a real-life experience with mobility difficulties city travelers: a go-along interview method

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Abstract. Providing physical accessibility to the city centre is crucial in ensuring that everyone has equal access to employment, health care, education and social life. There should be no exclusionary or discriminatory practices that prevent anyone, including disabled people or OKU (from the Malay ‘*Orang Kurang Upaya*’) from participating in society. However, evidence from numerous studies shows that OKU has fewer opportunities to participate in built environment activities than non-disabled people due to inaccessible design. Even though OKU’s inclusion is linked to having access to the physical space, little effort has been given to exploring OKU’s life experience in reaching the city centre. The original research was aimed to investigate the physical accessibility of Kuala Lumpur city centre, as an example of a city in transition, and its effects on OKU’s inclusion. However, this paper focuses only on demonstrating a go-along interview as one of the primary data gathering methods employed in the first author’s doctoral thesis. The qualitative research design includes twenty go-along interviews with participants with limited mobility in order to learn about their real-life experience travelling to the city centre. With the current access and facilities provided, mobility-impaired travelers, particularly wheelchair users, still require assistance to reach their destination. In general, the mobility-impaired travelers confronted physical obstacles in gaining access to buildings and the internal circulation and services, negotiating barriers at street level and using various transportation modes to reach places. The go-along journeys also demonstrated that OKU faces attitudinal barriers and psycho-emotional disablism in addition to physical barriers, which may contribute to exclusion.

1. Introduction

Accessibility is one of the aspects that contribute to social sustainability and fosters sustainable development [1]. Access to the built environment is a fundamental human right [2] and the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCRPD) acknowledges “*the importance of accessibility to the physical, social, economic, and cultural environment, to health and education and to information and communication, in enabling persons with disabilities to fully enjoy all human rights and fundamental freedoms*” [3]. Providing disabled people with access to the city offers them the opportunity to empower their daily lives. However, inaccessible built environments in urban areas often create an unjust situation [4][5], with inaccessible built environments leading to



poverty, lower education, and poorer health among disabled people [6]. Evidence suggests that disabled persons have less opportunities to participate in built-environment activities than non-disabled people due to inaccessible design [7][4]. In this paper, accessibility is regarded as a spatial issue that intersects with human biological and psychological conditions [8]. Due to human personal biography [9], disabled people's interactions with the environment vary depending on intrinsic and extrinsic factors [10]. In the PhD thesis of the first author, the go-along interview method (a form of a walking interview) was employed as this method has the potential to grasp some of the "*transcendent and reflexive qualities of human experience in situ*" [11].

The term 'disabled people' is preferred in this paper over 'persons with disabilities' because it recognizes that, as represented by the social model of disability, disability is caused in part by discriminatory processes within society [12][13]. Oliver [12], one of the social model pioneers, highlights that disabled people are hampered by society's inability to adapt, not by their impairments. In Malaysia, the terms 'disabled people' and 'persons with disabilities' are interchangeable. However, OKU (from the Malay '*Orang Kurang Upaya*') is the most often used term for disabled individuals in both English (as used in Malaysia) and Malay [14]. When referring to disabled individuals in Malaysia, the term 'OKU' is used in this paper to relate to the local context. Meanwhile, the term 'disabled people' is still used to refer to those who are disabled in general.

2. Objective

This article's objective is to demonstrate a go-along interview as one of the key data collection methods in investigating the physical accessibility of Kuala Lumpur (KL) city centre and its implications on the inclusion of OKU with mobility difficulties. In general, previous studies used accessibility checklists to investigate the (in)accessibility of buildings and public places in Malaysian cities [15][16]. Little regard has been paid to OKU's lived experience or psychological and emotional viewpoints. This ignores the dynamic relationship between disability and the built environment, as disability includes structural and psycho-emotional dimensions, as elaborated in the theoretical extension of the social model of disability [9].

3. Go-along interview as a primary data collection method

A go-along interview is a form of walking interview commonly employed in ethnographic research. A go-along interview includes the action when the researcher walks alongside the interviewee while the interview session is ongoing [17][18][19]. According to Evans and Jones [19], "*walking interviews generate richer data because interviewees are prompted by meanings and connections to the surrounding environment and are less likely to try and give the 'right' answer*". In the go-along interview method, data is acquired through participant observation and conversation [19]. Researchers can observe the conversations and the participants' facial expressions, body language, and intonation, all of which convey their emotions [14][18]. This qualitative method can provide answers to questions and issues that quantitative methods cannot offer [20]. In contrast, quantitative methods often rely on surveys and statistics [21], which do not allow participants to relate their personal experiences in-depth. Analyzing events that had psycho-emotional effects on disabled people, such as encountering physical barriers in KL city centre, required in-depth investigation.

Learning 'with' disabled people through directly listening to their voices differs from learning 'about' their experiences through study [13][14][22]. Participating in activities with OKU while accessing the KL city centre resulted in the researcher become more connected to their experience. The researcher spent time with each participant for a walk-along in the public realm and a ride-along using the individual's preferred transportation mode, either taking taxis, buses and trains, as well as riding in cars driven by participants to get to destinations. Accessibility of buildings was also assessed during the go-along journey. This method was developed to explore OKU daily spatial experiences, perceptions, satisfaction, and expectations regarding the existing access and facilities provided.

The journey began at the research participants' house or any other convenient meeting point near their residence in Klang Valley. The purpose of establishing this meeting place was to serve as a starting point for data collection in order to discover barriers that OKU faces when attempting to visit the city centre.

3.1. Sampling and recruitment of participants

The study involved twenty volunteers as research participants. To be eligible, the participant had to be an adult willing to engage in the study, including travelling to and spending time in the KL city centre with the researcher. The participant could be either a frequent or seldom visitor to the city centre and residing in Klang Valley. Individuals with mobility difficulties were recruited for this study because they are more adversely affected by physical accessibility issues.

Snowballing technique was used to recruit participants for the go-along interview. This technique is employed in situations where participants are difficult to find [20], as a person can pave the way for more people to participate. The first person addressed were drawn from the researcher's contact list from past involvement in volunteer activity. Before the go-along interview, participants were reached over the phone to seek their initial agreement to participate in the study and schedule an appointment to deliver the participant information sheet and obtain the consent form. These participants were asked if they knew of anyone interested in participating in the study. The majority of the candidates contacted agreed to take part. Only two candidates refused to participate right away, while two others cancelled after appointments were set up.

Ten of the twenty go-along participants with mobility issues used manual wheelchairs (those with polio, spina bifida, and spinal cord injury). Three participants used powered wheelchairs (those with cerebral palsy and congenital amputation), two participants used crutches (those with cerebral palsy and a single leg amputee), one person used a skateboard (polio survivor) and one with a prosthetic leg (single leg amputee). Three participants were unaided; two of them were affected by acquired brain injury, and one person was with clubfoot.

The diversity of physical mobility limitations provided the researcher with a greater understanding of the participants' needs in accessing the city. No criteria for mobility aids were established to take part in the study. Even though the participants' mobility aids and impairments were identical, they each had unique abilities, needs, and ways of negotiating with barriers based on their individual biography.

3.2. Setting-up

Participants were asked to select destination(s) in the KL city centre that they either currently go to, or would like to visit; these could be linked to their existing and aspirational activity for recreational, cultural, administrative necessities and business. The participants were given a list of categories of places/activities to choose from when planning the trip's itinerary and destination. The destination list was to spark ideas for the participants regarding where they might like to go. None of the categories was mandatory, and the participants were allowed to choose places on or off the list. For audio recording, participants were given a lapel microphone. It was critical to have appropriate recording equipment, including a noise-resistant or wind-guard microphone, since the journey could take place in congested areas, such as streets with noisy traffic in the background. Participants were reminded of traffic hazards and risks on the journey during the briefing for the go-along journey. They were also encouraged to use a zebra crossing or any other safe crossing option. However, a few participants disregarded traffic risks because they discovered that using the street rather than pedestrian walkways was the most efficient way to travel.

3.3. The journey

Several participants led the journey to demonstrate barriers to physical access from their previous experience. Some chose the places they would like to visit but did not lead the journey neither choose the route. They decided to explore the journey with the researcher, especially if it was their first time

visiting any desired site. Moreover, as they were accompanied, many participants thought that the go-along journey was a great way to discover new routes and places. Data were obtained before, during (including in a seated situation), and after the journey. Since the participants were given a lapel microphone for audio recording, several participants continued to express their thoughts and experiences in the audio recording while taking a break, including while using the restroom. Therefore, even when the researcher was not standing next to the participant, little data was missed. Throughout the journey, the participant's interactions with the surrounding environment were observed to evaluate the current physical access offered and cross-check with the participant's responses. This procedure includes video recording and photographing the participant with their permission. The average go-along journey took approximately eight hours, including the initial talk, consent process, and route selection. The journey's duration was flexible and depended on the condition of the participants. Some participants had several health issues, which could cause difficulty while travelling. Therefore, the participants were free to complete the session whenever required.

3.4. Participant companion

Participant's safety was also addressed during the go-along journey. The potential of the participant falling or becoming impeded by any physical barriers is one of the safety concerns. Hence, precautions were taken by offering the participants to have a companion. The participant's preference for being escorted on the journey was determined through a telephone conversation when scheduling the interview.

Eleven participants were accompanied, with five of them brought their own companions. Four of them requested the researcher to bring a male assistant because they felt that as a woman, the researcher might not be able to assist them in overcoming physical barriers, mainly when they required transfer from the wheelchair or supported in getting up or down a kerb. Fieldwork assistants were recruited through the researcher's contacts with social workers who had prior experience walking with people with mobility issues. Nine of the journeys were only the researcher and the participants, with seven of them mentioned that they could access the city on their own. Two of them required the researcher's assistance; one to push the wheelchair and another to climb steps and staircases without a railing.

However, the researcher felt difficulties in assisting the wheelchair user on the way to the destinations. They experienced several challenges in continuing their journey, for example, being obstructed by a tree and seating in a pedestrian walkway, as shown in Figure 1(a). They were only able to continue their journey with the assistance of a passer-by, a motorcyclist, who stopped and offered help to get the participant to the road (in enabling them to continue their journey), as shown in Figure 1(b). Yet, they also had to deal with other safety concerns, such as compromising their safety in confronting the incoming cars, and wheeling on a big gapped steel grating drain cover, as shown in Figure 1(c).

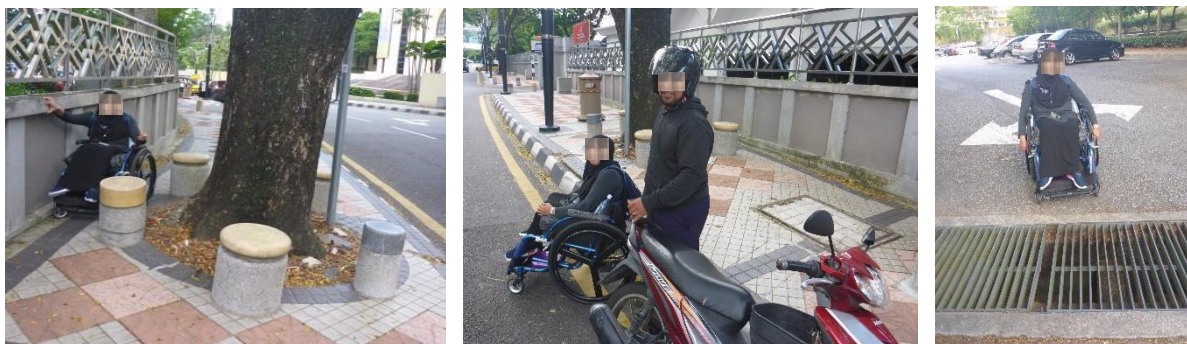


Figure 1. Confronting physical barriers at the street level environment, (a) landscaping that obstructs pedestrian walkway, (b) participant received assistance to get down to the road to continue journey, (c) steel grating drain cover design that imposed danger to participant

Source: Kamarudin (2021)

As a result, the researcher purposely requested that a fieldwork assistant accompany the two last journeys with wheelchair users, with the participant's approval. The companions or fieldwork assistants did not contribute to the interviews in any way.

3.5. *Compensation*

In return for their time and effort in being interviewed, each go-along participant receives RM70 (about GBP14) in cash. This amount is not large in that context, especially given the time spent. It is acknowledged that giving cash is uncommon for ethical reasons. However, as there was no assurance that retail places were all accessible to OKU, cash was favoured over vouchers. Additionally, the researcher covered the costs of the participants and their companions' meals and transportation. After receiving the compensation, participants were required to sign a receipt.

4. **Ethical consideration**

The majority of qualitative researchers uphold the relevance of ethical considerations with the obligation of respecting the informants' needs, rights, desires, and values [23]. The University of Birmingham's Ethical Review Committee gave this study full ethical approval. Participation in this study was entirely voluntary, and participants could withdraw and request that their data be deleted for up to three months after completing the journey. Information regarding the study was stated in the participant information sheet. At the start of the project, research participants were verbally informed of the research's purpose, and any queries from the participants were discussed. Generic identifiers were used in writing instead of the participants' real names, so participants could not be recognised from the data. To maintain the identity of persons photographed, all faces in images used in write-ups and presentations must be pixelated (also refer to Figure 1). Generally, the research participants verbally stated that they did not mind about having their identity being revealed. It was noted that participants seemed unconcerned about their anonymity. Several participants requested that the researcher share (or, as Malaysians commonly refer to it, to 'viral') their images while confronted with physical barriers, expecting that 'viral' issues would receive a quicker response from the responsible authorities.

5. **Data analysis**

The data obtained during four months of fieldwork (from January to April 2017) were independently analysed, and later combined using the analysis processes by transcribing, coding and creating themes [21].

5.1. *Transcribing*

To accurately transcribe an interview, the transcriber must pay close attention to the audio. The ideas and notions that emerged during the lengthy and in-depth process aided in producing a more profound analysis than would have been possible if the audio had been transcribed by others [24]. The researcher purposely transcribed all twenty go-along interviews because some of the conversations were difficult for others to listen to. All go-along interviews were performed in Malay and verbatim transcribed. Selected quotations for the thesis were later translated into English.

Due to the informal nature of the go-along journey, numerous participants spoke and asked questions irrelevant to the study. For instance, they asked about the researcher's hometown and experience living with family in the UK. These conversations were recorded but not transcribed.

5.2. *Coding*

Large data sets were generated in this qualitative research that must be managed. The most crucial part of the entire qualitative data analysis process is coding [25]. All data were coded to be coded quickly and systematically using ATLAS.ti, a qualitative data analysis software. Otherwise, coding would have been challenging to accomplish with note cards and word processors. The first round of hermeneutical keyword coding could be performed immediately following the import of the interview transcript. The coding was in English but the transcripts were not translated into English since there

was a risk of losing context throughout the translation process [26].

The researcher coded a single transcript at a time using a mix of emerging and predetermined codes. These predetermined codes were selected deductively based on the literature reviewed, expecting to receive some inductive codes. However, more inductive codes were formed, mainly when it came to the emotions of the go-along participants, which were either verbally or visually expressed when they encountered physical (and attitudinal) barriers and shared their experiences. The relative balance of inductive codes is approximately half of the total codes. The majority of the inductive codes were associated with the participants' emotions (e.g., feeling frustrated, discriminated, angry, unsafe, unfair, etc.).

5.3. *Developing themes*

Following an evaluation and re-examination of the coded data, similar data were grouped as a theme. The three embedded units of analysis that emerged were the street level environment, building/architectural design, and transportation. These three physical elements were significant to interrogate because they would present barriers (or facilitators) on city travellers with mobility difficulties.

6. **Reflections and conclusion**

Learning 'with' disabled people is believed to be more effective than learning 'about' their experiences or conducting formal interviews in understanding the disability-environment context. There were so many priceless experiences that the researcher would not have had through reading or listening, but only through the go-along journey. The researcher observed the participant and was involved with empathy in what the participant went through during the journey. The researcher directly faced challenges together with the participant, mainly when they could not obtain assistance from others (or help was offered late). Other knowledge discovered while carrying out this method could also contribute to a better understanding of an inclusive environment, including OKU's emotions while confronting the barriers. Besides gathering data on physical barriers, the researcher observed social behaviour while in contact with OKU and witnessed the unfavourable attitude among the general public while interacting with or not interacting with OKU despite their presence. The researcher also developed soft skills such as teamwork, communication, and adaptability while conducting this method.

The researcher's relationship with the go-along participants continues after the fieldwork is completed. However, the good relationship does not imply that the study is biased toward them. Other data obtained from various stakeholders' views and measures taken were also regarded relevant to understand physical accessibility in the KL city centre that affects OKU's inclusion. Eventually, the researcher noticed that the participants were interested in the study since it was directly relevant to their lives and future. Some participants were later keen to 'check' the researcher's progress in completing the doctoral thesis and hoped the findings would soonest be conveyed to responsible bodies related to physical accessibility.

The go-along interview method is the 'heart' of this research methodology. The researcher learned a lot about the relationship between accessibility and OKU, the importance of having access for them and how 'disabled' they were in an inaccessible situation. This method highlighted the lived experiences of OKU in reaching the KL city centre in a way that could not be learned in the same way anywhere else. Based on these real-life experiences, disability is regarded differently depending on individual biological factors (e.g., impairment, bodily function, age), psychological elements (e.g., determination), and social factors (e.g., access facilities). In order to facilitate OKU inclusion in the built environment, particularly in the KL city centre, accessibility should ideally begin when OKU leaves their home, using a range of transportation until they reach their destination. OKU's voice and perspective should be recognised and incorporated into design and policymaking, as OKU is the expert on barriers [27], having experienced them first-hand.

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